

Google Assistant gets native SDK to attract developers

Google has planned the expansion of the Google Assistant by launching its SDK. The latest move by the search giant is aimed at building an artificial intelligence (AI) powered ecosystem that is not just limited to Google apps and services and is also open to all developers.

"With this SDK, you can now start building your own hardware prototypes that include the Google Assistant, like a self-built robot or a voice-enabled smart mirror," wrote Chris Ramsdale, product manager of Google Assistant, in a blog post.

The SDK comes bundled with a gRPC API, a Python-based open source

client that handles authentication and access to the API, samples and documentation. Also, there are bindings for languages such as Java, Python, C#, Node.js and Ruby.

The cross-language support empowers the Google Assistant SDK to enable prototyping on hardware ranging from a smartphone or tablet to a Raspberry Pi 3.

Although Google has precisely provided most of the major features of the Assistant through the SDK, it still does not have the core hot word support. The engineering team at Google is also in development to bring about companion app integration.

Having said that, the initial SDK release is enough to influence developers to build new experiences for the Google Assistant. It could counter Apple's Siri and Microsoft's Cortana, over time.

You can check the features on the developer preview by downloading the Google Assistant SDK. A GitHub repository has also emerged to let you start developing your projects using the new offering.

Mozilla's JavaScript framework can understand Web pages just like people do

Mozilla is taking the Firefox browser to the next level with the Fathom JavaScript framework. The framework is helping the browser maker to extract the meaning out of Web pages.

Fathom is known as a mini-language for writing semantic extractors. As its name indicates, the Fathom framework picks out page descriptions, images and other items. The JavaScript framework is helping Firefox to understand the content and structure of a Web page. It is being used in the Activity Stream traffic tracker of Firefox.



Fathom can be implemented in a browser, in extensions and even server-side software. It is a data-flow language like Prolog.

Mozilla's developers have designed Fathom to calculate DOM nodes

based on user-specified conditions, annotations and a system of types. This process helps the framework to extract meaning from parts like address forms, previous/next buttons and textual content found on the website.

According to Mozilla's senior staff software architect, Erik Rose, the framework is still in the early stage of development. It nevertheless enables the browser to identify meaningful parts on a page and show the summary.

Rule sets in Fathom are JavaScript function calls that make annotations in the syntax tree version. These rule sets are capable of giving automatic tuning of score constants. Maybe future releases will learn and generate rules automatically.

Raspberry Pi starts supporting Snaps

Months after they received support on multiple Linux distributions, Snaps are finally making way for Raspberry Pi. A Snaps build—specifically designed for Raspbian—has emerged to deliver the advanced experience.

Snaps were initially a part of the Ubuntu platform. But last June, the self-contained, read-only images debuted on multiple Linux platforms to offer a secure solution for delivering system components and applications. That development had brought the Snappy technologies to distros such as Arch Linux, Debian, Gentoo Linux, Fedora, OpenSUSE and Yocto, among others.

Canonical developer Simon Fels has unofficially announced the availability of Snaps on Raspbian. Though Fels has managed to bring Snaps to the Raspberry Pi platform, it is yet to gain full support.

"I have initial packages for this available now and want to invite more people to help test these packages on their Raspbian package on their Raspbian systems," Fels wrote in a forum post on Snapcraft.

Notably, the latest development is of no use if you have the first-generation Raspberry Pi or the Raspberry Pi Zero. The work-in-progress is also not meant for any production system.

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